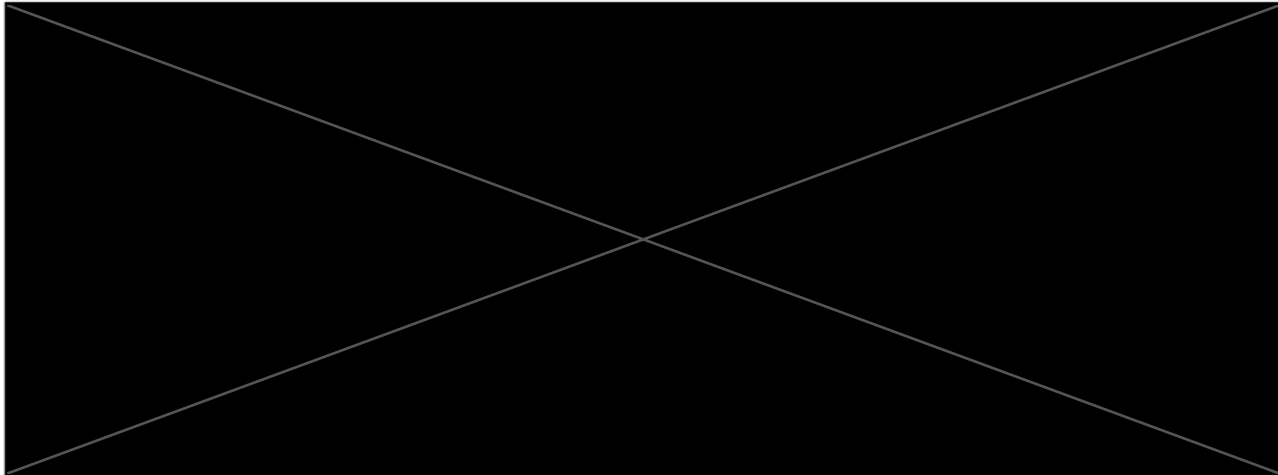
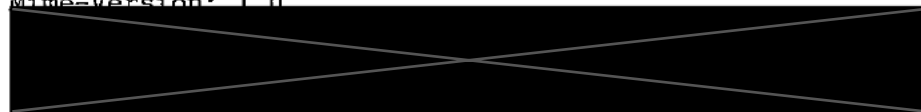


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To: (unknown), [REDACTED]
From: [REDACTED]
Date: 2/24/99, 4:02 PM
Re: Fwd: U.S. Steps Up Hunt For Source Of Amphibian Deaths



Subject: Fwd: U.S. Steps Up Hunt For Source Of Amphibian Deaths
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>From: [REDACTED]
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>Subject: U.S. Steps Up Hunt For Source Of Amphibian Deaths
>Date: Wed, 24 Feb 1999 13:10:00 -0600
>X-Mailer: Microsoft Internet Mail 4.70.1161

>Wednesday February 24 12:43 PM ET

>U.S. Steps Up Hunt For Source Of Amphibian Deaths

>By [REDACTED] Health and Science Correspondent

>WASHINGTON (Reuters) - Shocked by a "catastrophe" that is wiping out frog
>populations worldwide, a government committee met Wednesday to discuss what
>to do about it -- and whether humans are also in danger.

>"All amphibian biologists are now convinced that something unusual and
>catastrophic is happening to amphibians," Ron Heyer of the Smithsonian
>Institution told reporters.

>This consensus was needed before the government could really act, he said.
>It has decided to work fast.

>The committee, commissioned by the Interior Department, includes officials
>from the Environmental Protection Agency, the Health and Human Services
>Department, the National Institutes of Health, other agencies and
>environmental groups.

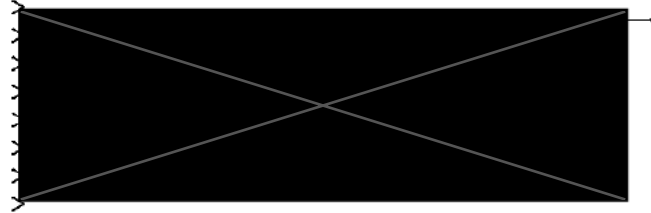
>Bill Brown, scientific adviser to Interior Secretary Bruce Babbitt, said
>President Clinton proposed adding \$8.1 million next year to the Interior

>Department's budget for studying amphibian decline -- a huge increase in
>the \$1 million now allocated.
>
>Although the United States has lost just one amphibian species to
>extinction -- the Las Vegas frog -- entire species have been wiped out in
>Costa Rica and Australia. And whole populations have disappeared in the
>United States, Puerto Rico and central America.
>
>Heyer said possible factors include ultraviolet radiation allowed through
>by the thinning ozone layer, climate change, and chemicals called endocrine
>disruptors because they mimic the effects of hormones on the body.
>
>Such chemicals can cause deformities and interfere with reproduction.
>
>''We also think the amphibians are telling us humans something has happened
>to the habitat we share with the frogs,'' Heyer said. ''We need to act on
>the early warning the amphibians are giving.''
>
>The decline in the United States first hit headlines when schoolchildren in
>Minnesota started bringing home horribly deformed frogs. But when
>scientists started looking, they found frogs were disappearing.
>
>''In some sites we are actually witnessing the decline as we try to study
>it,'' said Gary Fellers, a research biologist with the U.S. Geological
>Survey.
>
>He said one California species, the mountain yellow-legged frog, is a good
>example. ''Over a 10- or 12-year period this frog has rapidly declined,''
>he said.
>
>''Even at sites where we do find frogs, we find four or six or eight
>individuals.'' There used to be hundreds.
>
>There are a number of possible causes, said Fellers, who stressed that
>scientists are just starting to sort them out.
>
>''The most significant, we believe, is airborne contaminants -- pesticides
>and herbicides that are used in huge quantities in central California,'' he
>said.
>
>Prevailing winds blow the chemicals into the Sierra Nevada mountains. Those
>areas that get the most winds from the agricultural valleys have the fewest
>frogs, Fellers said.
>
>''We have not yet demonstrated that the contaminants have caused the
>decline. But ... those areas with the most contaminants are the areas with
>the fewest frogs,'' he said.
>
>Other possible causes are the introduction of fish into lakes where they do
>not naturally occur. ''They eat frogs and they eat tadpoles,'' Fellers
>said. It is also possible that disease is playing a role, he said.
>
>Other scientists have identified a fungus that kills some frogs.
>
>The researchers are reluctant to blame any specific chemicals. Not only has
>cause and effect not been proved, but many different chemicals are
>involved.
>
>Sam Droegge, also a research biologist at the USGS, said citizens can help.
>''They can actually help us in terms of collecting data,'' he said.
>
>The Interior Department, an environmental group and a children's television
>have set up an Internet site -- <http://www.frogweb.gov> -- to commission
>schoolchildren as a nationwide ''frog force.'' The site asks U.S. and

>Canadian residents to report sightings of normal and malformed amphibians
>encountered during outdoor activities.

>

>Ken



Regards



Web Administrator

CSETI

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